Heritage Values in Site Management
Four Case Studies

Marta de la Torre • Margaret G. H. MacLean • Randall Mason • David Myers

Edited by Marta de la Torre

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The Getty Conservation Institute, Los Angeles

The Getty Conservation Institute

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(4) Commemorative Integrity Statement for Grosse Île and the Irish Memorial National Historic Site (1998)
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PART TWO The Case Studies

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Grosse Île and the Irish Memorial National Historic Site

Margaret G. H. MacLean and David Myers

Management Context and History of Grosse Île

This section looks first at Parks Canada, the agency responsible for Grosse Île and the Irish Memorial, as an administrative entity and as a keeper of heritage sites on behalf of the Canadian people. The organization has evolved over time, and its purpose and mission are reflected in the way in which its holdings have been and are valued and managed. Following this account of the management context is a fuller description of Grosse Île itself, of its location in the St. Lawrence River, and of how it came to occupy a position of significance.

Parks Canada

The Parks Canada Agency was established on 1 April 1999 by an Act of the Parliament of Canada.[1]

The Chief Executive Office of Parks Canada reports directly to the minister of Canadian heritage. This minister "is responsible for national policies and programs relating to broadcasting, cultural industries, arts, heritage, official languages, Canadian identity, Canadian symbols, exchanges, multiculturalism, and sport."[2]

Prior to the passage of the *Agency Act*, Parks Canada had been part of three different departments during the period of time covered in this case study. For each of these three departments, the official responsible for Parks Canada was an assistant deputy minister. From 1974 to 1979, Parks Canada was part of the Department of Indian and Northern Affairs; from 1979 to 1993, it was part of the Department of the Environment; and from 1993 to 1999, it was part of the Department of Canadian Heritage.

The mandate of Parks Canada is "to protect and present nationally significant examples of Canada's natural and cultural heritage, and foster public understanding, appreciation and enjoyment in ways that ensure their ecological and commemorative integrity for present and future generations."[3]

The agency administers three systems—national parks, national historic sites, and national marine conservation areas—and other programs concerned with Canada's heritage.

The national historic sites directorate of Parks Canada "is responsible for Canada's program of historical commemoration, which recognizes nationally significant places, persons and events."[4] It comprises not only the historic sites but also the more than five hundred persons and three hundred events deemed to be of national significance. Parks Canada has direct responsibility for 145 of the 849 designated national historic sites across the country. The agency contributes to the conservation and/or presentation of an additional seventy-one sites through cost-sharing agreements.

Parks Canada has a broad range of responsibilities in the management of national historic sites. These include developing policies for conserving and presenting each site's cultural resources, for conserving natural resources, and for providing infrastructure for public visitation. These activities often involve consultation with interested members of the Canadian public. The agency also reviews existing heritage legislation in order to propose enhancements to federal law for the protection of national historic sites.

The federally appointed Historic Sites and Monuments Board of Canada (HSMBC, or "the Board") advises the minister of Canadian heritage on various aspects of the work of the historic sites program. The Board is made up of individuals representing all of the Canadian provinces and territories and some of the national heritage agencies. Their duties and functions are described in the *Historic Sites and Monuments Act*, and the Board develops its own policies and procedures, which are then approved by the minister. With the administrative support of staff from the national historic sites program, the Board examines new site or monument nominations, commissions research as needed, balances stakeholder claims, and formulates recommendations to the minister regarding designation and the most appropriate form of commemoration of a given subject.

The criteria for national significance (as stated by the HSMBC) are as follows:

A place may be designated of national historic significance by virtue of a direct association with a nationally significant aspect of Canadian history. An archaeological site, structure, building, group of buildings, district, or

Figure 1.1. National Historic Sites of Canada thematic framework.

cultural landscape of potential national historic significance will:

a. illustrate an exceptional creative achievement in concept and design, technology, and/or planning, or a significant stage in the development of Canada; or
b. illustrate or symbolize in whole or in part a cultural tradition, a way of life, or ideas important in the development of Canada; or
c. be most explicitly and meaningfully associated or identified with persons who are deemed of national historic importance; or
d. be most explicitly and meaningfully associated or identified with events that are deemed of national historic importance.[5]

Since 1981 the work of the Board in the identification of subjects for commemoration has also been guided by the National Historic Sites of Canada System Plan,[6] which provides a framework to ensure that the National Historic Sites System adequately represents each of the important historic themes in Canadian history. The system plan uses a thematic construct to organize history, classify sites, and provide a comprehensive view of Canadian history; the themes of the current plan are presented in figure 1.1. Today, Grosse Île and the Irish Memorial National Historic Site is associated with the "Peopling the Land" theme, under the subtheme "Migration and immigration."

Geography and History of Grosse Île

BEFORE 1832

Human habitation on Grosse Île prior to European contact appears to have been occasional and seasonal, probably attracted by the fish and game resources that still draw hunters to this area.[7] When the Europeans arrived in the sixteenth century, they quickly recognized the value of the St. Lawrence River, which gave their ships access well into the North American interior.

The first record of a land concession on Grosse Île dates to 1662, only fifty-four years after the city of Quebec was founded on the site of the indigenous settlement of Stadacona. For the next 150 years, Grosse Île was used primarily for hunting and fishing by nonresident colonial landowners. By 1816, records indicate the presence of homesteads and agriculture; farming continued on Grosse Île until 1832, when the island was expropriated by the government for use as an immigrant quarantine station.

1832 TO 1937

After the end of the Napoleonic wars in 1815, emigration to North America from Ireland, Scotland, and England surged. By 1830, Quebec had become by far Canada's largest immigrant port, accepting some thirty thousand entrants annually, two-thirds of whom came from Ireland. With these new arrivals came the cholera epidemic that was then raging in the British Isles; about thirty-eight hundred people died of cholera in 1832 in Quebec City,

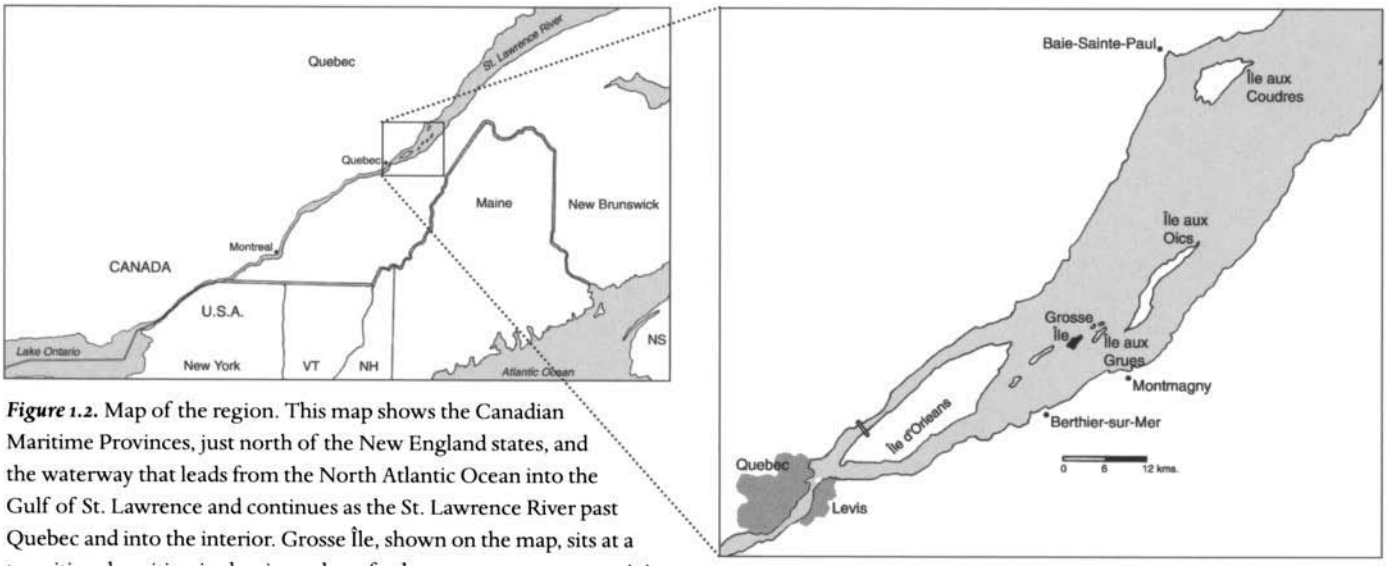

Figure 1.2. Map of the region. This map shows the Canadian Maritime Provinces, just north of the New England states, and the waterway that leads from the North Atlantic Ocean into the Gulf of St. Lawrence and continues as the St. Lawrence River past Quebec and into the interior. Grosse Île, shown on the map, sits at a transitional position in the river where freshwater meets seawater; it is therefore home to a distinctive array of flora and fauna. The towns shown on the south shore are those from which ferry service carries visitors to the island.

and half that number died in Montreal. With this, and with their experience with outbreaks of typhus among immigrants in the 1820s, the British authorities recognized the need for an immigrant quarantine station for the port of Quebec to check the spread of disease. They chose Grosse Île for its size, its harbor, its proximity to Quebec City, and its isolated position in the river.

The Great Famine raked over Ireland from 1845 to 1849; during its peak years of 1847–48, about 100,000 European emigrants came to Quebec City, most of them Irish. Already weakened by malnutrition, many contracted typhus and dysentery during the six-week sea voyage. Waves of gravely ill passengers overwhelmed the quarantine station's staff and facilities—there were only 200 beds for sick immigrants and about 800 for the healthy; yet, by the spring of 1847, more than 12,000 individuals were detained at Grosse Île.

Colonial authorities scrambled to build hospitals and shelters. When the station's facilities were finally adequate, the end of the sailing season stopped the seemingly endless stream of immigrant ships. During the course of 1847, more than 5,000 immigrants had perished at sea, and 5,424 more had died and were buried on Grosse Île. Thousands more perished in Quebec, Montreal, and other cities in eastern Canada.[8]

After a less-devastating epidemic of cholera hit in 1854, the function of Grosse Île began to change. From 1861 to 1900, while the average annual number of immigrants to Quebec City remained between 25,000 and 26,800, they were coming from different places. During this period the Irish became the minority; English emigrants were most numerous, and more Scandinavians and other western Europeans were joining them. They all were leaving considerably less-desperate conditions in Europe and Great Britain. They arrived in Canada in much better health, having been far better accommodated and fed on board than earlier immigrants. The replacement of sailing vessels with steamships cut the crossing time from Great Britain to twelve days—one-quarter of the previous passage. And, toward the end of the nineteenth century, St. John and Halifax, better connected to the country's interior by railroad, began to compete with Quebec as immigration ports.

During the economic boom from 1900 to 1915, annual arrivals to Quebec surged to 92,000. While emigrants from Great Britain still dominated and many still came from Scandinavia and western Europe, joining them now were people from the Middle East, Australia, North and South Africa, Asia, and the Caribbean.

During World War I and continuing through the Depression, immigration numbers dropped markedly. Between 1932 and 1941, Quebec received only a quarter of those arriving in Canada, reflecting the opening of new ports of entry, some on the Pacific coast. In February 1937, the Canadian government finally closed the Grosse Île quarantine station; it was no longer needed.

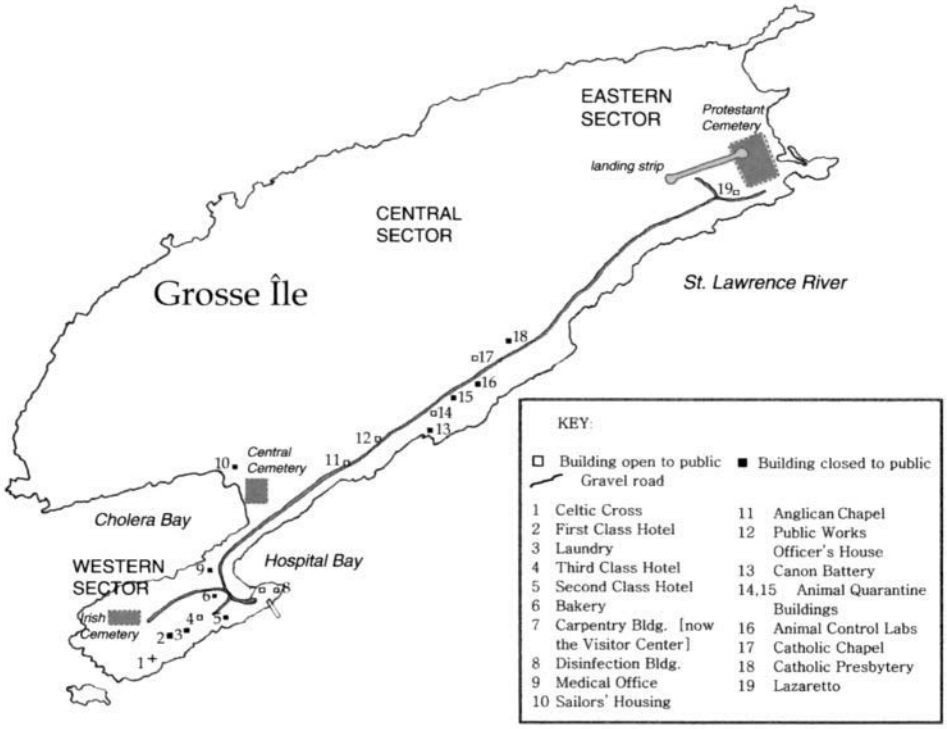

Figure 1.3. Map of Grosse Île. Grosse Île is one of the twenty-one islands in the Îles-aux-Grues archipelago in the St. Lawrence River, about 48 kilometers (30 miles) northeast (downstream) from the city of Quebec. The island is 2.5 kilometers (1½ miles) long and 800 meters (roughly half a mile) wide at its broadest point, with a land surface of approximately 185 hectares (457 acres). The shoreline includes beaches (at Cholera Bay), cliffs (on the southern edge of the Western and Central Sectors), tidal wetlands (Hospital Bay), and tide pools. Pine trees and other woodland plants cover much of the island north of the gravel road. Access to the island is largely by ferry from the south shore of the St. Lawrence River; staff and visitors are ferried to the wharf, which is located at the northeast end of the Western Sector. (Numbered and named features are discussed in the text and/or shown in photographs.)

1937 TO 1988

During World War II, under the Canadian Department of National Defense, Grosse Île became the War Disease Control Station. Taking advantage of the site's isolation, scientists experimented with viruses and vaccines to prevent the deliberate introduction of animal diseases to North America. Although this work ended in 1945, similar scientific work was performed there from 1951 to 1956 in response to the Korean War and the Cold War.

In 1957 animal disease research on the island shifted to the Canadian Department of Agriculture, whose work continued there until 1988. In 1965 Agriculture Canada's contagious disease division also started using the island as a quarantine station for imported livestock. Although there have been no animal quarantine activities on Grosse Île since 1986, lands and facilities used by Agriculture Canada are still subject to sectoral agreements between Parks Canada and Agriculture Canada.[9]

Grosse Île Becomes a Heritage Site

This section traces the evolution of the status of Grosse Île as a heritage site and discusses how ideas and contributions leading to an understanding of the site's values and significance emerged during this process and coalesced.

1897: THE FIRST PILGRIMAGE

Grosse Île was first recognized as a place of significance in 1897, when a group from the Ancient Order of Hibernians, an Irish Catholic fraternal organization whose members were Canadians of Irish descent, visited Grosse Île to commemorate the fiftieth anniversary of the terrible year of 1847. It is important to note that the Great Famine of the mid-1840s in Ireland was not a simple natural disaster; rather, it was a tragic coincidence of failed agricultural methods, harsh social policies, unrelenting poverty, and inadequate medical practices, the legacies of which still haunt English-Irish relations. At only fifty years after the fact, some who made the Hibernian pilgrimage to Grosse Île in 1897 were themselves likely to have been survivors of that traumatic time; others may have been relatives or friends of those who perished. For them and for many others, Grosse Île had the powerful and poignant quality of a cemetery of innocents.

1909: DEDICATION OF THE CELTIC CROSS

In 1909 the Ancient Order of Hibernians dedicated a Celtic Cross on a high promontory on the southwestern end of the island as a memorial to the lost immigrants. Inscriptions on the base of the monument testify particularly to residual bitterness about the conditions that forced

Figure 1.4. The Celtic Cross. Erected in 1909 by the Ancient Order of Hibernians to commemorate the Irish emigration, it stands on a south-facing cliff in the Western Sector of Grosse Île; cut from Irish stone, it is about 15 meters (49 feet) high.

the flight of so many Irish to the New World. The English inscription reads, "Sacred to the memory of thousands of Irish emigrants who, to preserve the faith, suffered hunger and exile in 1847–48, and stricken with fever, ended here their sorrowful pilgrimage." The translation of the Gaelic inscription reads rather differently: "Children of the Gael died in the thousands on this island, having fled from the laws of foreign tyrants and artificial famine in the years 1847–48. God's blessing on them. Let this monument be a token to their name and honor from the Gaels of America. God Save Ireland."

From 1909 on, the Ancient Order of Hibernians organized a nearly annual pilgrimage from Quebec City to the great stone cross, a tradition that continues to the present.[10] To go there as a pilgrim was to retrace the steps of one's forebears and to acknowledge the courage and pathos of the immigrants' journeys. The isolated location of the island and its minimal development easily evoked earlier times and surely added to the emotional power of the experience.

1974: HSMBC RECOMMENDS NATIONAL HISTORIC SITE DESIGNATION

In 1974, long after Grosse Île had finished its work as an immigrant quarantine station and had seen service as a biological testing station, an agricultural research station, and a livestock quarantine station, the HSMBC made its recommendation to place a commemorative plaque on Grosse Île. With the acceptance of this recommendation by the minister, Grosse Île became a national historic site. The plaque, unveiled in 1980, bore the following inscription:[11]

> In 1832, a quarantine station was established here on Grosse Île in an attempt to prevent the introduction of cholera from Europe. The station's medical and quarantine facilities proved inadequate in the face of the cholera and typhus which periodically accompanied immigrant ships; consequently, epidemics spread through the Canadas on a number of occasions in the course of the nineteenth century. Originally designed as a temporary establishment under military command, the station was later operated as a regular service by the Canadian government until superseded in 1937 by new facilities at Québec.[12]

1981: NATIONAL HISTORIC SITES OF CANADA SYSTEM PLAN

With the introduction of the National Historic Sites of Canada System Plan, all of the national historic sites were concatenated into a thematic framework, described earlier.[13] By categorizing sites according to themes and subthemes, the system plan aids the HSMBC and Parks Canada to see the strengths and gaps in the commemorative programs they oversee and to identify needs or opportunities for education programs or strategic planning.

1984: THE BOARD REAFFIRMS THE SIGNIFICANCE OF GROSSE ÎLE IN CANADIAN HISTORY

In 1983 and 1984, the HSMBC discussed at length the theme of immigration. The minutes of its meetings record that "the Board once more stated its opinion that the theme of Immigration is among the most significant in Canadian history." In the same meeting, the Board "reaffirmed its statement of June 1974 that the Quarantine Stations at Grosse Île and Partridge Island are of national historic significance" and recommended that "in light of the number and quality of the in situ resources on Grosse Île related to the theme of immigration, the Minister should consider acquiring the island, or portions of it, and there developing a national historic park."[14]

1988: GROSSE ÎLE COMES UNDER THE JURISDICTION OF PARKS CANADA

Following the recommendations of the Board, the environment minister (then responsible for Parks Canada) reached an understanding with the agriculture minister, and in August 1988 a formal agreement was reached between the two departments to transfer the buildings and sites of historical interest to Parks Canada.[15]

Figure 1.5. Two of the ferries that operate out of the private marina at Berthier-sur-Mer. The one on the left can carry 140 passengers; the one on the right, 50.

Figure 1.6. A view toward the east, showing the Disinfection Building and the Carpentry and Plumbing Building (now the Visitor Center and gift shop) at the left. Built in 1892 on the north end of the western wharf, the Disinfection Building housed three disinfection chambers and, eventually, showers. The south wing was erected in 1915; the north, in 1927. The Disinfection Building has been restored to its 1927 appearance; it is the first place modern visitors enter.

Beginning in the late 1980s and extending into the mid-1990s, the period covered by planning for the management of Grosse Île, there were significant policy changes and related developments in Parks Canada. These included the development and approval of the cultural resource management policy and of commemorative integrity, both of which were much more explicitly values-based than Parks Canada's previous policy documents. While it was a challenge for people involved in planning (and management) to integrate the latest thinking, there was, overall, surprisingly little lag between new policy direction and other activities.

Facilities and Services Today

Grosse Île and the Irish Memorial National Historic Site is open to the public May through October. High season for visitation generally lasts from mid-June through the beginning of September. All visitors to the island arrive by private ferry service from either the south shore of the St. Lawrence or from the port of Quebec. Ferries from the south shore depart from the ports of Berthier-sur-Mer and Montmagny (fig. 1.2). Most visitors depart from Berthier-sur-Mer for the thirty-minute boat ride to the island. This schedule allows visitors to stay at the site from two to four hours. In 2001, adult tickets from Berthier-sur-Mer were about $34 each, and a child's ticket (ages 6–12) was about $17.[16] Admission to the site is included in ticket prices (all quoted in U.S. dollars). The ferry service from Montmagny mainly transports site staff. The journey takes some forty-five minutes, depending on the tides. Two round-trip ferries depart from this small dock—early each morning and in the late afternoon.

Ferries from the port of Quebec are marketed as cruises offering sightseeing along the river rather than as transportation exclusively to Grosse Île. They are available by reservation only. The boat trip takes approximately three hours each way, thus allowing visitors to stay at the site for about three hours. Tickets for this service from Quebec are about $48 for adults and about $24 for children.

Upon arrival at the wharf on the south shore of Grosse Île, which is situated in the island's Western Sector, visitors are met by trained guides. Guided tours are divided into three parts. They begin with a visit to the Disinfection Building (location 8, fig. 1.3), where several exhibits explain the history and workings of the quarantine station. This building was fitted with bathing facilities for new arrivals and with a steam chamber for disinfecting their clothing and carried items.

Visitors can then take a sixty-minute hike around the Western Sector, to see the hotels and other facilities (locations 2–6, fig. 1.3), the Celtic Cross (location 1, fig. 1.4), and the Irish Memorial at the Irish Cemetery. This loop takes the visitors back around to a point at the head of Hospital Bay, where a tram takes visitors out to the Central and Eastern Sectors.

Figure 1.7. The Catholic Presbytery and the chapel next door, built in 1848 and 1874, respectively. The presbytery was remodeled in 1913, when a wraparound porch was removed and a second story was expanded. In the backyard of this structure, archaeological work, shown in figure 1.8, was done in summer 2001.

Figure 1.8. A small excavation in the back of the Catholic Presbytery. Opened in autumn 2001 as part of a water piping project, the dig revealed wooden piers on which a small outbuilding stood. While no traces of the building remained above ground, this find substantiates records and photographs of the time.

Figure 1.9. The Public Works Officer's House (location 12, fig. 1.3). It was an important building, judging from the quality of its decoration. The exterior has recently been restored, and the interior has been conserved.

Figure 1.10. The Anglican Chapel (location 11, fig. 1.3). Built in 1877–78, the Anglican Chapel was made of wood and set on masonry pillars. It was intended for the use of the staff and residents of the island, not for the immigrants. In order to preserve the structure's largely original appearance and to stop leaks, the pillars are being reinforced; a moisture barrier is being placed between the interior walls and the board-and-batten exterior skin; and the tin roof is being repaired.

This approximately sixty-minute tour includes a stop at the Catholic Chapel and Presbytery (locations 17 and 18, fig. 1.7) and the Lazaretto (location 19, fig. 1.3), where the interpretive scheme focuses on the tragedy of 1847. Fifteen of the buildings surviving from the quarantine station will eventually be accessible to visitors.[17] Several are undergoing conservation work and will be open to the public in the near future, such as the Public Works Officer's House, the Anglican Chapel, and the Marconi Station. The other historic buildings, as well as those from the Canadian Army and Agriculture Canada's occupation of the island, are not open to the public.

Some of the historic structures are used by visitors and staff for other purposes. The old Carpentry and Plumbing Building (location 7, fig. 1.3) houses the Visitor Center and its gift shop. The second floor holds the administrative offices of the site. The Disinfection Building (location 8) and the Third Class Hotel (location 4) house public washrooms. The Third Class Hotel also accommodates the cafeteria that serves visitors as well as site staff and others working on the island.[18] Rooms on the upper floors of this building are used as short-term sleeping accommodations for staff and others working on site. The Medical Examination Office (location 9) as well as some buildings in the Central Sector are also used as seasonal residences for staff.[19]

More-modern facilities on the island include an aircraft landing strip in the Eastern Sector, used exclusively by Parks Canada; a wastewater treatment plant; an underground water storage tank; and heating oil tanks.

integrity and Commemorative Integrity Statements require the input of experts, but they are not the private preserve of experts. The new guide also made some minor editorial changes to the definition of commemorative integrity, which now reads as follows:

> A national historic site possesses commemorative integrity (health and wholeness) when:
>
> • the resources directly related to the reasons for designation as a national historic site are not impaired or under threat;
>
> • the reasons for designation as a national historic site are effectively communicated to the public; and
>
> • the site's heritage values (including those not related to the reasons for designation as a national historic site) are respected in all decisions and actions affecting the site.

The new guide is available on the Parks Canada Web site at http://www.pc.gc.ca/docs/pc/guide/guide/commemorative_1_0_e.asp.

On the monitoring front, it was not until 1997 that Parks Canada began to explicitly report on the state of commemorative integrity of national historic sites. In that year, eight sites were reported on. One of the most interesting findings was that the greatest impairment to these eight sites was in the communication of national significance. Beginning in 2001–02, Parks Canada committed to evaluating the state of commemorative integrity for fifteen national historic sites a year. The Commemorative Integrity Statements serve as the basis for these evaluations.

Within a Parks Canada context, commemorative integrity has become the key component in planning, managing, operating, evaluating, and taking remedial action in national historic sites. The Commemorative Integrity Statement provides the core for national historic site management plans and annual business plans. Commemorative integrity evaluations point to where remedial management action is required, and, for an increasing number of managers, they are considered to be a prerequisite to any new management planning activity (how can you plan if there is not a sound understanding of the state of the place for which the plan is being done?).

Commemorative integrity will also be the centerpiece of new legislation planned for Canada's national historic sites, including sites not owned by Parks Canada. In little more than a decade, the values-based management approach inherent in commemorative integrity has gone from a conceptual construct to a way of describing our business. How could this have happened, given all the interests (managers, operations people, professional disciplines, stakeholders, etc.) affected and/or involved? A number of reasons can be suggested to explain this:

- the simplicity of the concept
- the emphasis on values and on a systematic and comprehensive articulation of values
- the focus on the site, rather than on an organization or specific activities or functions
- its usefulness as a management, planning, and evaluation tool
- its clear relationship to what we (should) do at historic sites
- the involvement and engagement of a broad range of people
- it's not exclusionary
- it's a unifying concept

Notes

1. Parks Canada 1994b.
2. Parks Canada 2002.

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